

Thursday, September 8

Up at 6:20. These long days are killers. Cheryl and I are restless at night. We sat with the boys awhile before the time came to go. We left shortly after Augusta arrived. Cheryl drove me part way.

Cheryl still doesn't know what she teaches. Some teachers refuse to teach anything but what they've done for many years. Just the same, she has several classes into her room and does puzzles and games with them. They seem to be very decent children. Most in her class are very average: the boys talk about BMX racing, BMX bicycles, BMX clothing. She has some marriage breakdown casualties. Children tell about arguing parents, the troubles of raising themselves, and so on. So often these children arrive unkempt, hair unbrushed, clothing wrinkled and worn, struggling to be with others.

Peter had his first day at school. Cheryl asked him what his teacher was like.

"Oh, she's nice."

"Is that all you can say?"

"In fact, she's probably the best teacher I ever had."

He tells us her name is Mrs Lymon. She has black hair. The kids did some art, "painted a foot," went for recess "while Mrs. Lymon went for tea," but the break was too short and Jennifer cried a bit when her parents left. Peter seems awfully calm about this. Perhaps he really isn't bothered by all this newness.

But this is having a ripple effect. Because kindergarten is the only thing in his life at the moment, nothing else seems important enough to do: tapes, toys, bike riding. All he does when he is at home is wander about with no purpose. He teases and disciplines Matthew, yells into his police microphone, giggles. Cheryl and I hope that school meets his high expectations. Most of his enrichment will happen outside school. We read to him, he learns the cello. Other things will come up for him to do.

The toll for a bad night's sleep was paid this afternoon at school. Active teaching feels too much at the moment; I want to work from my chair. But the

end of the day came and I am still alive. The kids I've been given are good, well-behaved, most of them quite strong academically. I made myself walk home at the end of the day.

After supper we went to Canadian Tire, Safeway and Grosvenor Park Shopping centre. We bought some groceries and a teaching book. At home the boys were put to bed. I have started The Book of Three with Peter. Matthew took twenty minutes to relax enough to fall asleep. Cheryl and I took turns sitting by his crib, heads resting against the rail while Matthew thumped his foot onto the mattress and puffs lightly. Cheryl read the paper. I watched a bit of a Viking-49er game and wrote in the Journal. We were in bed by 10.